Flowers have been a universal cultural object for millennia. They are an important aesthetic element in everyday life, and have played a highly symbolic role in our culture throughout the ages. Exchange of flowers marks respect, affection, happiness, and love. However, the biological purpose of the flower is very different from the way we use and perceive. Flower helps a plant to reproduce its own kind. This chapter discusses flowers, their arrangement, fruits and seeds which are the reproductive units of a plant.

Floriculture

Floriculture is a branch of Horticulture. It deals with the cultivation of flowers and ornamental crops. The Government of India has identified floriculture as a sunrise industry and accorded the status of 100% export oriented. Agriculture and Processed food product Export Development Authority (APEDA) is responsible for export promotion of agricultural and horticultural products from India.



4.1 Inflorescence

Have you seen a bouquet being used during functions? Group of flowers arranged together on our preference is a bouquet. But an inflorescence is a group of flowers arising from a branched or unbranched axis with a definite pattern. Function of inflorescence is to display the flowers for effective pollination and facilitate seed dispersal. The grouping of flowers in one place gives a better attraction to the visiting pollinators and maximize the energy of the plant.

4.1.1 Types of Inflorescence

Based On Position

Have you ever noticed the inflorescence arising from different positions? Where is the inflorescence present in a plant? Apex or axil?

Based on position of inflorescences, it may be classified into three major types. They are,

Terminal: Inflorescence grows as a part of the terminal shoot. Example: Raceme of *Nerium oleander*

Axillary: Inflorescence present in the axile of the nearest vegetative leaf. Example: *Hibiscus rosa-sinensis*

Cauliflorous: Inflorescence developed directly from a woody trunk. Example: *Theobroma cocoa, Couroupita guianensis*

Observe the inflorescence of Jackfruit and Canon ball tree. Where does it arise?



Figure 4.1: Cauliflorous inflorescence